



Worth every penny: Qatar did not turn heads only by hosting the tournament. It did so by winning it too. AFP

disarm Jordan 3-1 and win the title where Lionel Messi won the World Cup in 2022.

Qatar, in that tournament, had made itself a laughing stock, losing all three games and finishing as the worst-performing host.

Nearly 14 months later, it has become the King of Asia in style, with Afif putting on the hat of Houdini and celebrating with magic, literally, after scoring.

Tintin Marquez, taking charge of Qatar weeks before the tournament, helped the side play using through balls, quick attacks, and set-pieces. And the rousing reception at every

home game added further seasoning.

The host started with a 3-0 win against Lebanon and maintained clean sheets throughout the group stage, beating Tajikistan and China 1-0. It showed its pedigree in the knockouts, beating Uzbekistan on penalties, pulling off a comeback win against Iran and finally sealing the title against Jordan from a 1-1 position.

Qatar did not turn heads only by hosting the tournament. It did so by winning it too.

This Asian Cup pushed the old notions of clear-cut winners and



AWARDS

Most Valuable Player

Akram Afif

Highest Goalscorer

Akram Afif (8 goals)

Best Goalkeeper

Meshaal Barsham

Fairplay Award

Qatar